

SMU MS in AI for Business Advisory Board

June 9, 2026 | 9:00–9:30 AM CT | Microsoft Teams

SMU MS in AI for Business Advisory Board

June 9, 2026 | 9:00–9:30 AM CT | Microsoft Teams

Attendee: Aren Cambre (acambre@smu.edu)

1. Background / History

Aren Cambre is a Clinical Professor in the Information Technology and Operations Management (ITOM) Department at SMU's Cox School of Business. He holds a Doctor of Engineering in Engineering Management from SMU, along with an MS in Business Analytics from Cox. ZoomInfo lists his title as Program Director, MS Artificial Intelligence in Business, which aligns with his operational role leading the MSAIB program, though "Clinical Professor" is his official faculty designation.

Cambre has deep roots at SMU, having progressed from Adjunct Lecturer to Adjunct Professor to his current clinical faculty role. In parallel, he holds a staff role as Application Services Director, Web in SMU's Office of Information Technology (OIT), giving him an unusual dual position straddling academic instruction and enterprise technology operations. His research and teaching interests center on data analytics, web technologies, and digital transformation. He is the operational and academic lead for the new MS in AI for Business degree, working alongside ITOM Department Chair Amit Basu.

Prior to his SMU career, Cambre served as VP and Treasurer at Scarsdale Computers, a retail technology company, giving him a practitioner lens he brings to the classroom.

History with David / Improving: No prior documented relationship found in David's files or public sources. This appears to be an introductory or early-stage board engagement. Treat this as a relationship-building call unless David has direct context otherwise.

2. Company Overview

Southern Methodist University (SMU) is a private research university in Dallas, Texas. The **Cox School of Business** is its business school and consistently ranks among the top business schools in the Southwest. Cox houses the ITOM Department, which is the academic home for the new AI for Business program.

MS in AI for Business (MSAIB) is a new STEM-designated graduate degree announced by SMU Cox on August 5, 2025, with its inaugural cohort starting Fall 2026. Key program facts:

- **Format:** 9-month full-time or 21-month part-time
- **Credits:** 32 credit hours
- **Curriculum focus:** Predictive AI, generative AI, machine learning, LLM technology, AI ethics, business implementation, and data analytics
- **Tools covered:** Python, R, SAS, Tableau, Alteryx, Hadoop, Spark, NodeXL, Google Analytics
- **Design intent:** Bridge technical AI competency with business strategy and implementation leadership

- **Career outcomes:** Graduates targeting roles in analytics, AI consulting, data-driven leadership; prior cohorts from related programs have landed at Accenture, AT&T, Capital One, Amazon, EY, and PwC
- **Undergraduate pathway:** A 4+1 degree option exists for SMU undergraduates

The **ITOM Advisory Board** is an established industry advisory body for the department. Known current or recent members include executives from Oncor Electric, Mazda/Toyota, Lennox International, and Southwest Airlines. The MSAIB program may have its own emerging advisory board separate from or nested within the ITOM board. Vishal Ahuja (Advisory Board Member, TraumaCare.AI) has been referenced in connection with the program. The full MSAIB advisory board roster is not publicly listed.

The program is designed to leverage Dallas's status as a growing technology and business hub, and SMU Cox is explicitly positioning it as a regional talent pipeline for AI-capable business leaders.

3. Improving's Position

Why David is on this board: No formal documentation of Improving's membership or sponsorship was found in public sources or David's files. David's calendar confirms the meeting as "SMU MS in AI for Business Advisory Board" with Aren Cambre, indicating David has been engaged as an industry advisor. The most plausible rationale: Improving is an IT consulting firm headquartered in Dallas with deep expertise in software delivery, agile transformation, and emerging technology adoption, including AI. That profile is exactly what a new AI-for-business graduate program needs on its advisory board: practitioners who hire these graduates and can validate curriculum against real-world consulting and enterprise demand.

What Improving brings to the board:

- A regional IT consulting firm with delivery presence in Dallas and across North America
- Hands-on perspective on how enterprises are actually adopting and implementing AI
- A hiring lens: what skills and capabilities are consulting clients and Improving itself looking for in new AI talent
- Agile and software delivery expertise that contextualizes how AI projects succeed or fail in practice
- Access to a network of technology leaders across verticals who could be future partners, guest speakers, or employers for MSAIB graduates

Gaps to fill: David should clarify whether Improving has a formal advisory board seat, a sponsorship arrangement, or a more informal engagement. He should also know whether Improving has hired any SMU Cox graduates previously, or whether there is an active recruiting pipeline.

4. Proposed Agenda

This is a 30-minute Teams call. Suggested flow:

Time	Item
0:00–3:00	Intros and context-setting: Aren's role, David's role, purpose of the board
3:00–8:00	Program overview from Aren: where the MSAIB stands as it heads into Fall 2026 launch

Time	Item
8:00–15:00	Advisory board mandate: What does Aren/SMU Cox want from board members? How often do they convene? What decisions or input does the board influence?
15:00–22:00	David's perspective: What Improving is seeing in the AI talent market, what skills matter most, where new graduates are succeeding or struggling
22:00–27:00	Collaboration opportunities: recruiting, guest speaking, capstone projects, curriculum feedback
27:00–30:00	Next steps and calendar

5. Talking Points

On Improving's perspective on AI talent:

- What the market is asking for right now is not just people who understand AI tools, it is people who can translate AI capability into business outcomes. That is the gap Improving sees constantly on client engagements.
- The consulting lens is useful here: clients are not hiring data scientists, they are hiring people who can stand in a room with a VP and explain what an AI model does and why it matters to their P&L.

On curriculum and program design:

- Ask: Where does the current curriculum land on the spectrum between technical depth and business application? Is there appetite to adjust that balance based on employer feedback?
- Ask: Are there capstone or practicum components where industry partners like Improving could participate directly, either as problem sponsors or mentors?

On the advisory board structure:

- Ask: What is the expected cadence and commitment for board members? (Quarterly meetings? Ad hoc input? Curriculum review cycles?)
- Ask: Who else is on the board? Understanding the composition helps David know where Improving's perspective is distinct versus where it overlaps with others.

On recruiting and hiring:

- Improving should be on SMU Cox's recruiting radar for this program. If that relationship does not exist formally, this call is the right moment to establish it.
- Ask: What does the career services pipeline look like for MSAIB graduates? How are industry partners currently plugged in?

On Aren specifically:

- Cambre has an unusual dual role: faculty and enterprise IT operator. He has built things inside an institution while also teaching about technology. David can connect with him practitioner-to-practitioner, not just as an outside industry voice talking at academia.
- His D.Eng. in Engineering Management signals he thinks in systems and operational terms, not just theory. Lead with practical, applied framing.

Positioning Improving correctly:

- Improving is not a product company, it is a consulting firm that lives inside client technology transformations. That means board input from Improving is grounded in what is actually happening in enterprise AI adoption, warts and all.

- Dallas-headquartered, which matters for a program explicitly trying to build local talent pipelines. Improving can be a local anchor partner.